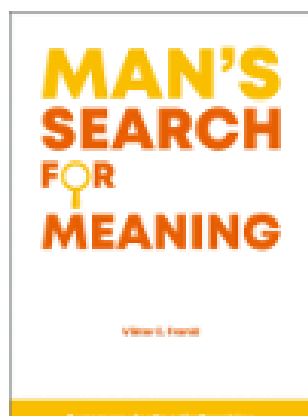




MAN'S SEARCH FOR MEANING

VIKTOR E. FRANKL



The Big “So What”

Renowned psychiatrist Viktor Frankl survived the Nazi death camps as a prisoner. His years of suffering, experiences and insights led him to develop logotherapy, a branch of psychology built on the belief that humans are primarily driven by meaning. **In this book, he chronicled his camp experiences and how logotherapy can be used to help people overcome anxiety and find happiness and fulfilment in life.**



Introduction

In a concentration camp, all meaning and life goals are stripped away. When left with nothing but the skin on their backs, how do some prisoners persevere and survive while others collapse or give up? Frankl believed that **meaning and purpose are powerful driving forces that allow mankind to overcome extreme odds and achieve extraordinary feats.** His experience in the concentration camps reinforced his beliefs and inspired him to develop logotherapy.

In this summary, we've organized the key ideas into 2 parts:

- The physiological journey of a concentration camp prisoner; and
- Logotherapy: how to address anxiety and find meaning in life.



Part 1: A Concentration Camp Prisoner's Psychological Journey

During WWII, Frankl spent 3 years (1942-1945) in Auschwitz and other concentration camps as a prisoner. During this period, he observed that **the prisoners went through 3 psychological phases with corresponding symptoms: shock, apathy and depersonalization.**

KEY QUOTES

"Man's search for meaning is the primary motivation in his life and not a 'secondary rationalization' of instinctual drives."

"An abnormal reaction to an abnormal situation is normal behavior."



Phase 1: Admission to Camp → Shock



When the prisoners entered the camps, most of them went into shock. They couldn't handle the stress nor process the implications of their new situation, and reacted in ways that would've seemed abnormal under normal circumstances. Yet, abnormal reactions to abnormal circumstances are actually normal and expected. Such "abnormal" reactions included (i) delusions of reprieve, (ii) humor, (iii) curiosity, and (iv) a lack of fear.



Delusions of reprieve. When faced with dire circumstances, we *want* to believe that things will miraculously work out, even when evidence suggests the contrary.

- Frankl arrived at Auschwitz with 1,500 people. The prisoners originally thought they were being sold to a factory as forced labor and were shocked to realize the train had arrived at a concentration camp. But when they saw a small group of well-fed, healthy-looking camp prisoners boarding the train, they told themselves that things may not be that bad. Then, they were split into 2 groups, and the larger group (with 90% of the newcomers) was sent to death within a few hours.
- Frankl was part of the minority that survived. When the remaining prisoners were told to surrender all their possessions and valuables, some still naively requested to keep certain items. They simply couldn't process that they could lose everything overnight, including their identity and past lives.
- However, bit by bit, their hopes and illusions were stripped away. Their clothes were removed, their heads and bodies were shorn, and they were whipped/beaten at the slightest provocation. Frankl finally realized that he was literally left with nothing but his naked existence.



No fear of death. Everyone knew of the high death rates in concentration camps. Yet, the very knowledge of their impending death made death less fearful.

KEY QUOTES

"We, too, clung to shreds of hope and believed to the last moment that it would not be so bad."

"No one could yet grasp the fact that everything would be taken away."

 Humor. Instead, the prisoners tried their best to crack jokes, e.g. making jibes about how there was actually water in the showers.

 Curiosity. Next, a strange, detached sense of curiosity set in, e.g. if someone got seriously injured, he may wonder if/how he'd survive the injury, rather than fear the outcome per se. This was the mind's way of protecting itself from the horrors all around. In fact, the prisoners were often surprised at how much they could endure, e.g. they could stand wet and naked in the autumn chill without catching a cold, or survive with very little sleep.

Phase 2: Routine → Apathy

 New prisoners missed their loved ones and felt disgust, horror, and pity at the level of death and suffering. One of the worst pains was the mental-emotional trauma of being treated like animals. Yet, the initial shock of Phase 1 wore off as the prisoners settled into a routine and transited to their grim new reality. In Phase 2, apathy set in, i.e. they became numb to the physical and psychological pain of the daily beatings and abuse.

 Apathy served as a protective shell or a defense mechanism. It allowed the prisoners to conserve their strength to focus on the overriding goal of survival.

- The prisoners were severely underfed and undernourished. They spent long hours doing manual labor, but were given only ≤10.5 ounces of bread a day, with 1.75 pints of thin soup, and small daily "allowances" in the form of bits of margarine, honey, jam, cheese or sausage. Over time, they lost their fats/muscles and became skin and bones. Once their immunity system collapsed, the death toll rose even further. They needed every ounce of energy to stay alive.
- Things that used to bring feelings like horror or disgust no longer affected them. When a prisoner died, others would apathetically salvage the dead man's food, clothes, and possessions.

KEY QUOTES

"The most painful part of beatings is the insult which they imply."



Phase 3: Liberation → Depersonalization



After the prisoners were liberated, they entered a 3rd Phase: depersonalization, where they felt disconnected from their own bodies, thoughts and feelings, as if they were observing their life from the outside in a dreamlike state.

- When the prisoners were finally freed, they didn't feel the joy or excitement they'd expected. They'd become so emotionally numb and detached that they had forgotten how to feel.
- Moreover, the survivors would've at some point dreamt of being free before waking up to the terrible reality that they were still imprisoned. Thus, their minds didn't dare to believe that the freedom was real. Their starved body, however, showed no such reservations and they ate with an endless appetite.



After prolonged mental pressures and physical captivity, sudden liberty can be dangerous. It's similar to how a diver can die from the sudden change in pressure if he rises to the surface too quickly from the ocean depths. Many liberated prisoners suffered from 3 key negative responses:

- In some cases, the oppressed became the oppressor. They felt justified to harm/hurt others like how they'd been hurt.
- They also felt bitter when other people didn't seem to acknowledge or care about what they'd been through. They questioned what all their suffering was for.
- They felt disillusioned when the world they returned to wasn't what they'd imagined it would be. Often, the liberated prisoners returned to their hometown only to find their loved ones gone, and things were no longer as they remembered.



Despite the adjustment difficulties, at some point all the liberated prisoners were able to look back with wonder at how they survived the camps, and feel as if there was nothing else to fear (except perhaps God).

KEY QUOTES

"We had literally lost the ability to feel pleased and had to relearn it slowly."

"'Freedom'—we repeated to ourselves, and yet...we could not grasp the fact that freedom was ours."

"We were not hoping for happiness...And yet we were not prepared for unhappiness."



Coping Mechanisms

Despite the horrifying camp life, many prisoners managed to retain their sense of self, find psychological relief and even inner peace. Frankl observed that **survival and self-preservation depended much more on mental-emotional strength than physical strength**, and the survivors often demonstrated several coping mechanisms.



Rich inner lives. No matter how unbearable our external circumstances, humans have the ability to retreat into an inner psychological space of peace and safety. Prisoners who had rich inner lives coped much better than those who didn't.

- It's possible to find humor, joy and laughter in anything. Frankl challenged his friend to come up with at least 1 amusing story each day, focusing on an amusing scenario after their liberation (e.g. something silly at a family dinner or at work).
- Art and beauty can enrich your inner life and trigger wonderful memories. Where possible, the prisoners improvised with music and poetry, or paused to admire a beautiful sunset. Even when they were being transported from one concentration camp to the next, they could admire the Salzburg mountains from the train.
- Many prisoners deepened their religious and spiritual beliefs in camp, finding pockets of time and hidden corners to run makeshift religious services.
- During his imprisonment, Frankl came to realize the power of love as a life-force. Even if a man has nothing, he can still feel joy and bliss by thinking of something/someone he loves. Frankl often conversed with his wife in his head, and focused on his loving memories of her to distract himself from his pain. He didn't know if she was still alive, but he decided he would act in a way that'd honor her.
- The prisoners also used their imagination to escape temporarily from their camp life, e.g. talking about the favorite dishes they'd have when they went home. Many dreamt regularly of a life of freedom.

KEY QUOTES

"(The) intensification of inner life helped the prisoner find a refuge from the emptiness, desolation and spiritual poverty of his existence."

"Humor was another of the soul's weapons in the fight for self-preservation."

"As the inner life of the prisoner tended to become more intense, he also experienced the beauty of art and nature as never before."

"Love is the ultimate and the highest goal to which man can aspire."

"The salvation of man is through love and in love...a man who has nothing left in this world still may know bliss, be it only for a brief moment, in the contemplation of his beloved."



Goals for the future. A concentration camp prisoner was reduced to a number. He had no name, no possessions, and no idea if/when he'd ever be free. Frankl was simply #119104 and spent the bulk of his time digging and laying tracks for railway lines. It was like being stuck in a "provisional existence" without an end-date.

- Many prisoners committed suicide since they felt they had nothing to live for. Yet, those with life goals somehow found a way to persist. Once you know your "why", you'll find the "how".
- Frankl helped many of the prisoners to set future goals, e.g. to return to a son/wife, finish writing a book series etc. Even small goals (e.g. planning a favorite dinner menu or family event) gave people something to look forward to.



Perception of Choice. Despite the suffering in a concentration camp, prisoners still had choices.

- Prisoners constantly decided if they'd push to survive another day or simply give up. They chose whether to let the camp degrade them to an animal, or stay true to their human values and sense of self. Some prisoners chose to abuse others while others offered comfort and shared what little food they had. Some guards were sadistic while others chose to be kind. You can choose to retain your human dignity even in a death camp.
- In 1945, there was an outbreak of typhus. After surviving typhus in his own camp, Frankl volunteered for medical duties at another typhus-wrecked camp. This would increase his risks of dying from the disease, but he decided he'd rather die with purpose. Later, Frankl almost escaped with other prisoners when an opportunity arose. Yet in the end, he chose to stay with his patients, and this decision brought him a profound sense of inner peace. On hindsight, Frankl realized that things seldom turned out as expected; his life was saved on many occasions when he chose what felt right rather than what he thought would've served his self-interests.
- No matter what your external circumstance are, you *can* choose how to interpret the situation and find meaning in suffering, e.g. see it as an opportunity to test your inner

KEY QUOTES

*"He who has a why to live can bear with almost any how."
— Nietzsche*

"Every day, every hour, offered the opportunity to make a decision, a decision which determined whether you would or would not submit to those powers which threatened to rob you of your very self, your inner freedom."

"Man can preserve a vestige of spiritual freedom, of independence of mind, even in such terrible conditions of psychic and physical stress."

strength and grow yourself. Even if you're terminally-ill, you *can* choose what to do with your remaining time on earth. In fact, such choices often define who you truly are as a person.



Part 2: Logotherapy and the Power of Meaning



What is Logotherapy?



Frankl's experience in the concentration camps inspired him to develop logotherapy. "Logos" stands for "meaning" in Greek, and Logotherapy is a psychological approach that focuses on the meaning of human existence.

- It's built on the principle that humans are motivated by meaning. **We want to know why we exist, what we're supposed to do, and that there's value in our existence.**
- In a survey of college students, only 15% indicated the most important thing to them was "making a lot of money", compared with 78% who chose "finding a purpose and meaning to my life". In a public-opinion in France, 89% said that humans needed something to live for, and 51% said there was something or someone they'd die for. Similar results were found in Vienna.



Unlike psychoanalysis (which treats neurosis by examining the patient's past), **logotherapy focuses on introspection and what the patient wishes to fulfill in the future**. Frankl asserted that the search for meaning should not be treated like a disease or dysfunction.

- Specifically, we suffer from "existential frustration" in 3 ways:
 - (i) Frustration with existence itself (i.e. the things we must be/do to exist as a human);
 - (ii) Frustration with the meaning of life in general (i.e. why are we here?); and
 - (iii) Frustration with the meaning of our personal existence (i.e. what am I here for?)

KEY QUOTES

"Man...is able to live and even to die for the sake of his ideals and values!"

"Existential frustration is in itself neither pathological nor pathogenic."

These may make us feel empty, detached and lost, but they don't mean we need psychiatric help.

- Instead of trying to “fix” the patients with drugs and analysis, logotherapy is simply about guiding patients through their growth or developmental crisis. For example, a high-ranking American diplomat was dissatisfied with his career and struggled to adhere to America's foreign policy. For 5 years, he underwent psychoanalytic treatment, and his analyst insisted that his job dissatisfaction was rooted in his problematic relationship with his father. Finally, the diplomat approached Frankl. After a few sessions, they established that there was a conflict between his vocation and desire for meaning. He found contentment once he switched to another profession.
- It's also a flawed assumption that a healthy mental state means being in perfect balance/equilibrium. Often, inner conflict and tension helps us to grow, improve and deepen our self-awareness. Constructive tension—the tension between where you are and where you can/want to be—drives you to take action and push beyond your current boundaries. **Good mental health isn't about being conflict free; it's about how you address conflicts in your life.**



What's The Meaning of Life?



There's no universal definition for the meaning of life, since such meaning varies from person to person and from moment to moment. It's just like how there's no such thing as the best chess move in the world—the “best” move will depend on the specific game, players and their respective strategies and counter-strategies. **What truly matters is the meaning of your life right now.**

- No two people are the same, and every life situation is unique. This means that you're fundamentally responsible for each and every choice that you make. **Instead of asking for the meaning of life, look to your daily choices as they'd show what you are making of your life right now.**
- To assess if you're making a right decision, fast-forward to the moment when you're on your deathbed, and ask

KEY QUOTES

“Mental health is based on a certain degree of tension, the tension between what one has already achieved and what one still ought to accomplish, or the gap between what one is and what one should become.”

“What matters...is not the meaning of life in general but rather the specific meaning of a person's life at a given moment.”

“Logotherapy sees in responsibility the very essence of human existence.”

“Live as if you were living already for the second time and as if you had acted the first time as wrongly as you are about to act now!”

yourself if you'd be happy with the choice you're about to make. Then make your decision as if you've been given a second chance to do it right.

- Instead of telling the patient why, what or how to behave, the logotherapist's role is to help him to see himself, the world and his range of options clearly, so he can make enlightened choices.



Frankl disagreed with a key assumption in psychoanalysis—that humans' behaviors are pre-determined by biology and external conditioning. He believed that mankind is self-determining: no matter what happened in the past, what we decide *now* will shape what happens next, and thus redefine our existence, who we are and who we're becoming. **Your past does not pre-determine your future.**



3 Paths for Finding Your Meaning in Life

There's no easy or straightforward way to discover your meaning in life, though logotherapy offers 3 broad approaches do to so:



Through action, i.e. the deeds you perform or the things you create. This could include the things you do/create in your work, family, social, personal or religious life.



Through your positive inner experiences with something (e.g. goodness, truth, beauty, nature) or someone. Love, in the context of logotherapy, goes beyond romance and sex; it's a deeper experience of togetherness. You can only see someone's innermost qualities—including their potential—if you love them. Your love in turn empowers them to actualize their potential, and creates the feeling that they're seen, accepted, challenged yet supported. Love is a powerful force—that's why people are willing to make sacrifices to give their children a better life, to make their partners happy, or to contribute to a bigger cause.



Through suffering. Suffering is unavoidable (e.g. losing someone we love), but we *can* seek to find meaning in it. In fact, if you're "stuck" in a situation you can't change (e.g. if you're diagnosed with a terminal illness), then the only thing you can do is to change your own attitudes and perspectives.

KEY QUOTES

"Man is capable of changing the world for the better if possible, and of changing himself for the better if necessary."

"By making him aware of what he can be and of what he should become, he makes these potentialities come true."

"When we are no longer able to change a situation...we are challenged to change ourselves."

However, while you can find meaning in suffering, you don't *need* to suffer to find meaning—suffering unnecessarily is basically being masochistic.

- There are 3 key types of suffering—pain, guilt and death—and you can find meaning in all of them:
 - (i) See *pain* as sacrifice. A man had been depressed since his wife's death 2 years ago. After speaking with Frankl, he realized that his wife would've been the one in pain if he had passed away before her. He now saw his suffering as a form of sacrifice to spare his wife the pain, and his depression disappeared.
 - (ii) Use *guilt* to improve future actions. Logotherapy can help reduce recidivism by redirecting guilt about the past into constructive actions. If criminals can choose to commit a crime, they can also choose to learn from and rise above their mistakes.
 - (iii) Use *mortality* to inspire responsible action. Human life may be fleeting, but once you make a decision and take action, you create real outcomes that leave a permanent footprint. If you live to your fullest and make the most of *every* moment, you'll have no reason to look back with regret when you're old.
- What if your suffering is so great that you simply can't find any meaning in it? Well, animals are used in medical tests to study diseases/cures. They undoubtedly experience pain and suffering, much of which they can't comprehend. Likewise, there could be a wider purpose to our suffering that we simply can't grasp.

❖ For all 3 paths above, true meaning and actualization will always come from focusing on something beyond yourself, e.g. giving yourself fully to a cause or to loving someone.



Addressing “Collective Neurosis”



Just like how each individual has his/her unique purpose, each generation has its unique psychological challenges. The present generation is grappling with nihilism—the belief that life is empty and meaningless.

KEY QUOTES

“In some way, suffering ceases to be suffering at the moment it finds a meaning, such as the meaning of a sacrifice.”

“Suffering is an ineradicable part of life...Without suffering and death human life cannot be complete.”

“Self-actualization is possible only as a side-effect of self-transcendence.”



How did an entire generation end up in an existential vacuum? Ironically, it's partly a result of our freedom and better living conditions.

- Our human ancestors had to rely on primal animal instincts to survive and procreate; they simply had no need/ability to ponder about the meaning of life. With cultural progress, our roles and behaviors were dictated by tradition, religion and social norms, so there was still minimal need/opportunity to define our own roles or purpose in life.
- In modern societies, we've lost touch with many traditions and are free to make our personal choices. Without others telling us what to do and believe, we feel lost. When we're bored, we feel discontented and seek to fill our inner void. With automation and longer lives, we may also find ourselves losing the jobs that used to give us our sense of purpose and identity.



Frankl believed that logotherapy is a much better approach for dealing with nihilism than traditional psychotherapy.

- Logotherapy assumes that life has meaning, asserts that you're free to and responsible for defining what to do with your life, and focuses on helping people to identify their options for the future. It directly addresses the void that people are grappling with.
- On the other hand, the most popular psychoanalytical approach (by Sigmund Freud) asserts that humans are driven by pleasure, and our behaviors are determined by our past experiences. This only reinforces the view that we're pawns to our biology and social conditioning. Focusing on your past may also lead to a downward spiral if those were the same experiences that taught you life was meaningless.



Using Logotherapy to Counter Anxiety



When we're anxious, we tend to get fixated on the causes of our anxiety, creating a loop called "anticipatory anxiety". Frankl explained 2 conditions associated with anticipatory anxiety:

KEY QUOTES

"The logotherapist's role consists of widening and broadening the visual field of the patient so that the whole spectrum of potential meaning becomes conscious and visible to him."

- Hyper-intention is when you focus so much on something you *want* that you end up sabotaging it. For example, the more you try to achieve a sexual orgasm, the harder it is. Or, the more you try not to sweat, the more likely you will.
- Hyper-reflection is about paying too much attention to something you *don't want*, only to worsen it, e.g. a woman became frigid not because of the childhood sexual abuse she suffered, but because of the amount of psychoanalytical research she did thereafter which amplified her trauma.

 These conditions can be countered using logotherapy:

- Counter hyper-intention with paradoxical intention, i.e. consciously plan to do the *opposite* of what you're afraid of. If you're anxious about sweating during a speech, flip it around by challenging yourself to show the audience how much you can sweat. If you're trying to fall asleep, challenge yourself to stay awake as long as possible.
- Counter hyper-reflection with dereflection, i.e. redirect the focus *away* from yourself to something external or wider. By alleviating the anxiety, it inadvertently helps to achieve your goals. Continuing from the example above, the frigid woman found it easier to achieve orgasm when she shifted the focus away from herself to her partner instead.

 Fundamentally, you can't force happiness. Pushing too hard will only cause hyper-intention. When we over-emphasize the need to be constantly happy and in-balance, we end up feeling bad/guilty for being unhappy, thus making things worse. **Instead of directly searching for happiness, it's much more effective to search for a *reason to be happy*.** It's like how you tell a joke to make someone laugh, rather than force him to laugh. **When you find meaning in your life, you automatically find hope, motivation and happiness, actualize your potential and create an upward spiral.**

Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This book is actually a combination of several of Frankl's works, including a narrative of his concentration camp experiences, an overview of logotherapy and an elaboration of its philosophy and

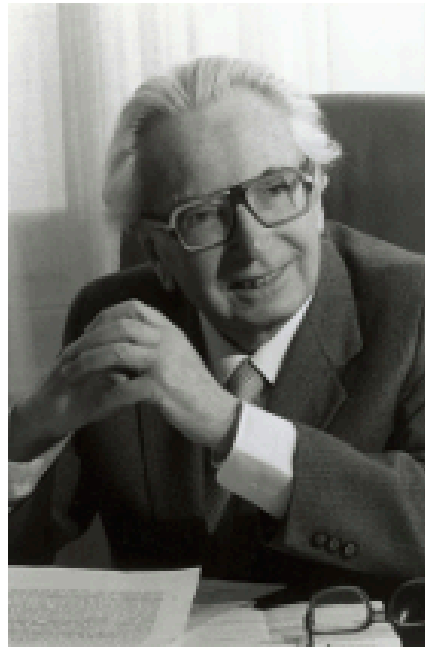
KEY QUOTES

"Happiness cannot be pursued; it must ensue. One must have a reason to 'be happy.' Once the reason is found, however, one becomes happy automatically."

practices. It includes many detailed narratives, examples and discussions about life, meaning, logotherapy and its applications. For more details, please visit www.viktorfrankl.org.

About the Author

Dr. Viktor Emil Frankl (1905-1997) was an Austrian neurologist and psychiatrist. He founded logotherapy, a school of psychology, after he survived the Holocaust during WWII. Dr. Frankl received the degrees of Doctor of Medicine and Doctor of Philosophy from the University of Vienna. Dr. Frankl was a Professor of Neurology and Psychiatry at the University of Vienna Medical School and Distinguished Professor of Logotherapy at the U.S. International University.



He was also a visiting professor and guest lecturer at several universities around the world, the President of the Austrian Medical Society of Psychotherapy and Honorary Member of the Austrian Academy of Sciences.

KEY QUOTES

"Every negotiation reaches a point where you need to communicate to the other side that they've pushed you as far as they can."